villain for the first *Iron Man* film, before the story took a different turn. "Early—and very late—drafts of *Iron Man 1* featured the Mandarin as a villain," Kevin Feige explains. "The Mandarin is Iron Man's most famous foe in the comics mainly because he's been around the longest. But if you look, there's not necessarily a definitive Mandarin storyline in the comics.

"So it was really about having an idea. In terms of the Fu Manchu stereotyping that was involved, we never had any interest in that. He's relentless; no other villain has been able to strike that fast and that hard at one of our heroes."

Crucial to the modern-day realization of the Mandarin was the casting of acclaimed actor Ben Kingsley. He brings both a weight and a humor to a character whose motives are often elusive. "He's so excited about his part and so into this character, and frankly just scaring the heck out of everybody," Feige says—including, of course, Tony Stark.

And Tony already has plenty of enemies—including, at times, himself. "I think the most important statement in his entire life, onscreen, was at the end of *Iron Man 1* when he said, 'I am Iron Man,'" Broussard says. "Because he said that, but he didn't really know what it meant. We've spent a lot of the movies since then exploring what that means.

"Once we tracked his journey, where he'd been in the three films to date, we started to plan where he would go in the next one—that continuous exploration of what it means to say, 'I am Iron Man.' What are your responsibilities when you have all this intellect, all this money and power, and now access to these other supreme beings that you're working alongside? Where do you go from there? How do you keep growing, how do you keep balancing your life—while also still having interesting relationships with the women in your life, the friends in your life? How does it affect all that? We've basically spent three movies exploring that one sentence and what it means: I am Iron Man. Because it's just so endlessly fascinating."

In addition to the villains and character conflict, *Iron Man 3* features the largest array of Tony Stark technology ever assembled on film—a mind-blowing assortment of Iron Man armors designed for land, sea, air, and even space.

"We built 41 suits for this movie," Alonso says. "One of our biggest, most complicated challenges was that every suit—whether it's for a particular sequence where there's only one suit or whether there are multiples—had to have a personality and a look that audiences could enjoy. That was a big challenge.

"In this movie, the suits have their own A.I.—Tony can control them. One thing we did in *Avengers* is that he actually flies, lands, and the suit opens up in motion as he's walking into



Cover to *New Avengers (2005) #8*
by Steve McNiven, Danny Miki & Frank D'Armata.